

TAKEAWAYS

- AI systems are far from resembling human intelligence, and better understood as a form of computational statistics
- Given the large digital divide in India, the datasets are incomplete and will entrench societal bias
- We need strong regulations to address the harms of AI. Regulation can in fact drive better innovation

of innovation and progress, despite privacy, labour and other issues. We need less of this business model, not more.

Looking Ahead

The current model of commercial AI depends on whatever data is available, and given the large digital divide in India, these datasets are necessarily incomplete and will entrench societal bias. It also concentrates power in the hands of commercial actors and risks displacing hybrid knowledge systems. A different model that centres the public interest is needed.

In many ways, in India, we are at a pre-AI stage—we are still in the process of digitalisation. This creates a unique opportunity for us to build and curate datasets that are inclusive, participatory and problem-driven. This will require investing in civil society and grassroots organisations that have a long history of delivering public services and building multidisciplinary partnerships that bring together domain and technical experts. The market alone is unlikely to incentivise such data curation—considerable and ongoing investments will be required from the government and philanthropy. The current fascination with larger and all-purpose AI models may also not be the best pathway. Instead, we need to focus on smaller, more specific models, which are built on intentionally and locally curated datasets and enable auditability and accountability.

We also need strong regulations to address the harms of AI. There is a false narrative that regulation and innovation are at odds with each other. Instead, regulation can drive better innovation, the boom in the market for electric vehicles being a prime example. Many of the tools we need are already available in existing regulatory frameworks. We need to use competition law to address the concentration of power in the hands of a few technology companies and uncompromisingly uphold tenets in privacy legislation around consent, data minimisation and purpose limitation. The past decade of social media platforms, or the recent fiasco around Sam Altman's exit from and return to OpenAI, should also make abundantly clear that self-regulation is not enough and commercial interests will tend to always dictate company action.

Finally, we need to develop civic capacities and institutions to continually audit these systems. This will help build public trust and ultimately drive adoption. Current policy debates seem to assume that simply making systems 'open' is enough to ensure accountability. However, openness does not in itself translate to accountability or harm reduction. There are significant steps in between, the most important being the capacities and systems to audit these systems and hold companies accountable. Transparency without adequate capacity can easily become the enemy of accountability. ■